



Capital City Cyclists

An Eight Day Cycling Adventure: The C&O Canal and the Great Allegheny Passage Trails.

by Jane Fletcher, Cindy Gaulin, Debby Kearney, Laurie Koburger and Jane Ann Mann, July 25, 2009

The C&O Canal Towpath and the Great Allegheny Passage Rail Trail together make one continuous 335 mile off-road trail from Georgetown in Washington, DC to McKeesport just outside of Pittsburgh, PA. The trail tells the story of our country's quest to find a route westward for commerce and industry. In fact, the concept of the C&O canal was put forth by George Washington who started the company that eventually developed the C&O canal.

First, the trail follows the C&O canal with its magnificent structures (aqueducts, dams, locks and lock tenders cottages) and ancient technology relying on the properties of water, gravity and human ingenuity. For nearly 100 years the canal was the lifeline for communities and businesses along its route as it floated coal, lumber, grain and other goods to market. The C&O canal is now a 184.5 mile long National Historical Park.

At Cumberland, MD the canal ends and the trail picks up abandoned rail lines and continues 150 miles to Pittsburgh through tunnels and across impressive viaducts. The railroad built a nearly level rail bed through the Allegheny Mountains that is now a flat out gorgeous trail for bikers and hikers

When planning our trip we debated the various ways we could make the trip--from an organized tour where we paid others to take care of all of the details to a completely self contained trip, and ended up somewhere in the middle. Our group of 5 women decided to stay in hotels and bed and breakfasts (no camping for us) and to take turns driving a SAG vehicle to move our luggage each day. We had no trouble finding places to stay near the trail and there are quite a few web sites and books to provide information on trip planning (See resources at the end of this article)

Day 1: We started our trip on Sunday June 21 with beautiful weather that stayed that way until the 8th and last day of the trip. We started riding at the Independence Mall in Washington, right by the Lincoln Memorial. We made a tour of the Lincoln Memorial, the Korean War Memorial, the Viet Nam Memorial, and the World War II Memorial then headed out to find the beginning of the towpath. A local cyclist pointed us in the right direction to find the cycling trail that would get us to the C&O Towpath.



The adventuresome 5 facing the Lincoln Memorial with photographer facing the Washington Monument.

Finding the C&O towpath in Georgetown is relatively easy, but finding mile marker "0", which is not on the current towpath, required some local knowledge. Another local cyclist showed us the way, which required winding through a circuitous footpath. Mile Marker "0" is in the shadow of the Watergate Complex right next to the remains of the original "watergate."



At mile marker "0".



The watergate after which the hotel is named.

After a photo op showing that we did indeed start at the very beginning of the trail, we sped out at the speed of tar in winter, (or, more accurately, the speed allowed by four photographers who were wowed by every sight). The towpath is a dirt path that runs along the abandoned C&O canal and for the most part runs between the canal and the Potomac River.

At Mile 13.9 we came upon Mather Gorge, a 75' sheer drop down to the river, and shortly thereafter the beautiful and powerful Great Falls. After watching a reenactment of a canal boat being lifted in a lock and moving forward up the river under mule power we stopped

for lunch at the snack bar at the Great Falls Tavern (1828). The tavern is now a canal museum, but the snack bar offers lunch of hotdogs, barbeque sandwiches, and ice cream.



Mather Gorge.



Canal boat being pulled by a mule.

Twenty miles into the ride the gooey, stick-to-your-tires, unavoidable, mud grabbed hold of us. Our choice was the river, the canal, or the mud. We embraced the mud and it embraced us from head to toe. Soon shouts of “mud” and “puddles” became so frequent that we experimented with different ways to describe them. “Mud with stick,” “stick in the puddle--studdle,” “muddle,” “this is just a damned mess,” “mumph” and singing these in many tones.



Just one of many puddles.

At mile 35.5 we arrived at White's Ferry – the only working ferry on the Potomac and the only way to cross the river for miles. Bike riders load last but pay only \$1 for the trip. On the other side we arrived in Leesburg, VA, where we stayed at a Best Western that advertised a shuttle service. The trip into Leesburg is several miles on a busy highway, much of it without a shoulder. The shuttle is

recommended. Be sure to reserve the shuttle ahead of time. The Best Western folks got a hose out for us to wash down the extremely muddy bikes.

Day 2: The towpath is complete with 75 locks and a large number of aqueducts. Morning 2 we came upon the Monocacy Aqueduct. It is the longest along the canal at 526 feet long. It was begun in 1829 and finished in 1833 and is a lovely structure with 7 arches. The Monocacy aqueduct played a part in the Civil War. During the Civil War the southern army tried to blow up the aqueduct so that the trade route would be disrupted. However, the first attempt didn't work. Then the lock keeper persuaded the southern troops that they really didn't need to blow up the stone aqueduct; they could just blow up the lock and serve the same purpose. So, the southern troops blew up the lock instead. The union army was able to rebuild the lock in a few days and trade was restored quickly.



Monocacy Aqueduct.



Riding along the canal.

We stopped for lunch in Brunswick, MD, at Beans in the Belfry, an old church that has been converted into a coffee shop/restaurant/cybercafé. It's just a short hop off the trail, has a bike rack, and was delicious, homey, and a great choice. We highly recommend it.

Back on the trail for 6 miles, we diverted to Harper's Ferry. We locked up the bikes on the MD side of the river and walked up the spiral stairs and across the footbridge into Harper's Ferry, WVA. There are some excellent ice cream parlors in Harper's Ferry and it was an ideal stop for dessert. Ladies, we can let you in on the news that there are lots of very cute gift shops and artisanal jewelry shops. We did read some of the historical markers, but must confess that we shunned the museums in favor of shopping. (Shopping rule: Nothing bigger than jewelry.) Interestingly, at this part of the trail, the Towpath and the Appalachian Trail coincide.

It was fun to see some power hikers along the way. We got off the trail at Mile 76, in Sharpsburg, MD. Great place, but be warned, the trip from the trail into town is heartbreakingly steep but nonetheless gorgeous. (DO NOT believe anything you read to the contrary in the trail guide. We heard a rider grind into the granny gear as we were walking our bikes uphill...). For history buffs, the town abuts the Antietam Battlefield. We stayed at the Mary Hill House, a log-based home built in 1780 that housed wounded confederate soldiers during the war between the states. The town has some good eating establishments, and Nutter's Ice Cream parlor is not to be missed. (Noticing a trend???)

Day 3: Downhill back to the towpath – Nice! At mile 76 we came upon the Killiansburg Cave, where local townsfolk hid during the long and bloody Antietam battle. More troops were killed in this battle than in any other in American history.

There is a detour at mile 85, which extended the mileage we had planned on. We didn't really believe the detour applied to us so we got further and further into the mud until we determined that indeed it did apply to us. The detour took us off the trail. It was hilly and hot once we got off the water. We were happy to be reunited with the towpath some 5 miles later. BUT, there were signs of another detour. We again did not obey the signs but this time we were able to navigate without turning around, but did carry our bikes across the rocky

path and rode across a stone wall with the river on one side and big rocks on the other. Not bike friendly. Whew.



Maneuvering through the area intended for detour.

We continued on toward Williamsport MD, where we stopped for lunch. A visitor's center in the Cushwa Warehouse (coal and brick) has trail information. A museum had an interesting traveling experiential exhibit about how to build a suspension aqueduct and a keystone arch bridge. The Desert Rose Café on the main street was yummy and the bike shop across the street was welcoming.

After lunch we passed up Fort Frederick and took our first opportunity to move from the towpath to the Western Maryland Rail Trail and it was heavenly. Pavement took the place of the muddy, rutty, difficult towpath and we felt like we were sailing. We stayed in Hancock, MD that night. Dinner was at Weaver's Restaurant, which claims the best desserts on the trail. Breakfast at the Park and Dine was terrific and from the looks of the desserts we believe they give Weaver's a run for their money.

Day 4: We spent some quality time with Dennis and Judy at the C&O Bicycle Shop, where they fixed us up with cool T-shirts and a replacement computer for one that jumped off Cindy's bike the previous day. The next stretch was quite deserted, but the scenery was spectacular. A diversion to Bill's Place in Little Orleans was fun. Fortunately we had a big breakfast and powerbars along the way because Bill had decided not to cook on that day. We were happy with a lunch of soda and pretzels. We didn't want to push Bill, as he was moving a bit slowly and he was tethered to an oxygen tank. We thought it was pretty darned good that he opened the place up and was working. He was delightful and we enjoyed visiting with him.

Mile 156's Paw Paw Tunnel was quite an experience. It is $\frac{3}{4}$ of a mile long and pitch black. While there is a wood fence keeping you from falling into the stagnant water of the canal, one could (and did) envision that the fence might not hold if you fell into it. Looking at the light at the end of the tunnel was disorienting. The trick is to look only a couple feet ahead of your headlight. Debby learned this after leaving some skin on the tunnel wall. Too slow or too fast leads to loss of control. (Too bad we didn't notice the recommendation to dismount and walk bikes through). Once out of that dratted tunnel, Paw Paw, WVA turned out to be a really nice place. We stayed at Grandma's Country Kitchen. Grandma's has a bike barn and she fed us well. Our rooms were spacious and comfortable.



Paw Paw Tunnel.

Day 5: We left Paw Paw at 6:30 a.m. so that we could make it to Cumberland in time for the Western Maryland Scenic Railroad's train that runs from Cumberland to Frostburg, PA. The sausage biscuits at the gas station that opened at 5:30 a.m. were, well, just okay. We booked it for 30 miles and made the train with time to spare. This is where one of us made the mistake of replacing her bike seat. Don't do this in the middle of your trip.

The train ride was scenic indeed and also eliminated 15 of the 22 miles uphill. In truth, the grade never exceeded 2.8 percent and for the most part was closer to 1.5 percent. This is the beginning of the Great Allegheny Passage. The trail here was a crushed limestone, hard-packed surface that was very smooth to ride on and a huge difference from the rocky, bumpy, rooty towpath. Lunch at the Mountain City Café in Frostburg requires charging up a steep hill, but is good and yes, they have ice cream!

We crossed the Eastern Continental Divide, the Mason Dixon line, and went through the Big Savage Mountain Tunnel, which was much different from the Paw Paw Tunnel. It was lighted and it didn't have any murky water in it to fall into. Once we crossed the Continental Divide everything was downhill—but that was a good thing. (Actually, the grade is so minor that it doesn't really feel like going downhill. It just doesn't take as much effort to ride.)



Eastern Continental Divide.

We ended the day in Meyersdale, PA. It was a luxurious downhill to the Burgess House, a delightful rental house built in 1897 and still owned by the original family. We found it interesting to stand on the front porch of this historic house and see a wind farm with windmills from the space age. We ate dinner in Garrett, MD at a Mennonite restaurant. Our ice cream came along with pie on this occasion. Delicious!

Day 6: Continued on the beautiful GAP, riding past the wind farm and Wymp's Fossil Quarry. The Pinkerton Tunnel is closed and a detour around the mountain was as pretty as it was long. We enjoyed Confluence, PA at mile 246. Among the several dining establishments, we had lunch at the River's Edge B&B across the river from the trail. It was wonderful. The fantastic dessert tray diverted our ice cream needs. This would be an excellent place to stay. It is owned by folks who were riding the trail, wished to exit the rat race, saw the house, and bought it to turn into an inn and restaurant to serve those using the trail. It's been open for 20+ years and is a favorite of cyclists. We moved at a good clip on to Ohiopyle, PA so that we could make it in time for a tour of Fallingwater, probably the most noted home designed by architect Frank Lloyd Wright. We were awestruck by the beauty of the home and the architectural innovations of Mr. Wright. His view of bringing nature into the structure resulted in a waterfall flowing through the house. What a cool thing!



River's Edge Café, Confluence, Pennsylvania.



Fallingwater.

Day 7: In the morning, we planned to do some river rafting on the Youghiogheny River in the Ohiopyle State Park but with the heavy rainfall and flooding the preceding weeks the river was quite turbulent and we opted to hike along the river. The hike to Cucumber Falls was breathtaking and we enjoyed jumping from rock to rock on the river. We were interested to see the natural water slides. We saw one brave soul get flushed down the natural water slide, but after we noticed him checking his body for bruises, we decided we didn't need to try that. We had enough bruises already from wayward pedals and the like.



Cucumber Falls in Ohiopyle State Park.



At the river's edge in Ohiopyle State Park.



Man braving the natural water slide.

Lunch at the Firefly Grill in Ohiopyle was good. Ice cream at the corner shop was really good. It was our first ice cream on this 3-ice cream day. We stole a little time to shop at the Wilderness Voyager outfitters. What a great place. We got a little carried away and made purchases that were bigger than jewelry. (See Shopping Rule from Day 2). A large part of the riding on Day 7 was through the Ohiopyle State Park. Wow. Our favorite overlook/photo op was on this part of the trail.



Resting at scenic overlook on the Youghiogheny River.

Be prepared to stop for photos often. We proceeded onto Connellsville, PA. This city greets the rider with an art show. Large above-ground tanks were painted by a local artist to represent the four seasons. Children from the community have painted pictures which are affixed to a fence along the path into town. We enjoyed visiting the town's bicycle shop and were pleased to learn that the bike shop also serves ice cream so we felt compelled to sample it. In Connellsville, the trail goes right through the town and the city park (bathrooms!) and provides a change of scenery.

We stopped at Dawson where we had the good fortune of staying with friends. The old stone guest house was built in the late 1700's. Even better, the house came with a large vegetable garden and fruit trees and bushes. We foraged snow peas, English peas, beans, carrots, beets, many lettuces and made the best meal of our journey. We picked lots of raspberries and had them over our third ice cream of the day.

Day 8: We stopped in West Newton for lunch –the Trail Side Café. Good. The trail was nice through Boston. As we neared McKeesport and the Greater Pittsburgh area, the trail was much different. We rode through industrial areas and through people's backyards. The trail becomes a little hard to follow, has a more difficult gravel surface, and has higher hills than the trail heretofore. We ultimately popped out onto a highway, crossed the Youghiogheny River one last time and cruised to the ending point.



We made it to McKeesport!

We had a great time, learned some American history and enjoyed some incredible scenery. Amazingly, not one of the five of us had a flat tire or mechanical malfunction during the trip. It was a great adventure for all of us and we are already talking about what our next bike escapade might be. Maybe the Erie Canal in 2010???

Resources:

C&O Canal : <http://bikewashington.org/canal/> , <http://www.nps.gov/choh/>, <http://www.canaltrust.org/>, <http://www.candocanal.org/>

Great Allegheny Passage Rail Trail : <http://www.atatrail.org/>

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